Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI



behaviour change campaign, but not as a politics of freedom.

The survey echoes what I have observed in the 11 years I have worked on themes around sexual relationships through Agents of Ishq, a project on sex, love and desire. People speak with assertive confidence about a growing catalogue of topics—consent, queerness, polyamory, kink—most of which they learn about online. But they are often masking uncertainty, confusion, ignorance, inhibition, hurt and a fear that they conform to neither traditional ways of being nor contemporary scripts of modernity.

I am not dismissing awareness. After all, much doing comes from knowing. But to move beyond reciting the politics to living it requires a more heterogeneous conversation on consent that recognises the sexual autonomy of women and queer people. However, sexual autonomy itself exists within a wider politics of autonomy that requires more than slogans and needs room for complexity and constantly building collective understandings. Consent is woven in with many desires: what we eat, where we work, how we dress, whom we love, how we express ourselves, who we are. And these desires are rooted in multiple contexts, of caste, of region and religion, of sexual orientation, and of our unpredictable poetic selves. In a word, we may call these things personhood.

TO MOVE BEYOND RECITING POLITICS TO LIVING IT, WE NEED TO REIMAGINE CONSENT DISCOURSE—GIVING IT NOT JUST SCALE, BUT DEPTH AND VARIETY

The granular acceptance of this personhood, our ability to listen to each other and respect difference, might be called a larger culture of consensuality, an intimate solidarity. This personhood is also the bedrock of equality, and equality is at heart about access to resources, material as well as cultural.

The survey's finding that economic strength has a bearing on women's positive experiences of consent speaks to the relationship between equality and consent. It is not generative to have atomised conversations about consent. They can be vibrant only if rooted in larger political conversations and struggles that imagine a culture of consensuality between people, between communities and castes, and between governments and citizens.

We have seen, as recently as in the case of Twisha Sharma, the visceral denial of this idea of personhood and sexual autonomy as something to be subdued. We have seen, in recent cases of dowry and intimate partner murders, that women earning their own money and cultural capital, manifesting autonomy, can call up a violent backlash from their own families. And we have seen, in the overturning of trans rights, the State's refusal to acknowledge personhood.

What the survey points to, then, are not simply more conversations about consent but more types of conversation about consent, more politically integrated understandings of consent and freedom. As we watch a new youth movement, the Cockroach Janta Party, make the opposite journey today, from the internet to the streets, perhaps the time is announcing its approach. ■

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